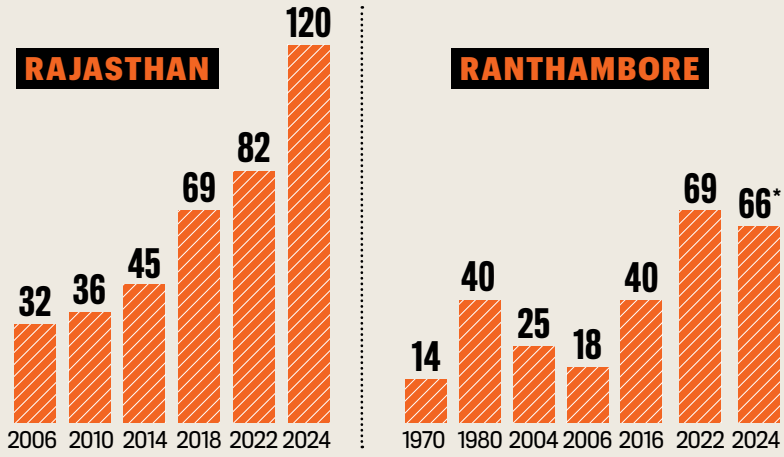
ESTIMATED TIGER NUMBERS



** Excludes the 15 missing tigers*
Source: Rajasthan Wildlife Department

5,975
SQ. KM
Total area protected for the tiger in Rajasthan



◀ Night prowl A Ranthambore tiger caught on trap camera

Vishdhari in 2023 and thereafter became the first tigress in Bundi district in decades to have cubs, was found dead a month after she went missing. On November 3, a mob in Ranthambore brutally killed a tiger, T-86, using stones, sharp-edged weapons and explosives after it killed a villager. However, even though T-86 sat next to its victim for 30 minutes before moving away, it was not tracked or secured by officials.

Some believe that the case of the missing tigers was exaggerated to deflect attention from the killing of T-86; some officials say publicising that half of the tiger population has been missing was a fallout of factionalism amongst forest officers. "The controversy over the missing tigers seems to have resulted from conflict amongst officers at Aranya Bhawan in Jaipur (headquarters of the wildlife and forest departments). They exposed themselves by ordering an inquiry into 25 missing tigers and the next day bringing it down to 15," says Mehta.

Whatever the reason, the state forest department faces two questions: what exactly is the number of tigers in Ranthambore and why have the 15 missing tigers not been flagged for months? Wildlife expert Dharmendra Khandal who has been making independent headcounts of tigers at Ranthambore for over two decades for Tiger Watch, an NGO, believes that the numbers of adult male tigers is 25 and that of females 22, which matches the 2022 census number of 52. Such a number takes into account mortality, shift to other areas and adulthood of cubs. Still, the mismatch of this number with the 88 claimed last November, is glaring. Some experts believe the number was inflated so as to enable politicians to take credit before the assembly polls in November. However, a more likely motive might have been the constant pressure from prominent politicians to shift tigers from Ranthambore to the new reserves of Mukundara and Ramgarh Vishdhari. A narrative that Ranthambore is overpopulated, as a result of which tigers are straying into human habitations, justifies such shifts.

Equally, it is also likely that some conscientious officials decided to publicise the high number of missing tigers to stymie the demand to shift Ranthambore tigers to newer sanctuaries where mortality rates have been very high.

Relocating tigers, though, can become a necessity. "We should shift more males from Ranthambore to balance the sex ratio here and also in Sariska, where females heavily exceed males," says a senior officer. Ideally, there should be one male for two females.

REASON FOR CONCERN

Interim reports on the missing tigers at Ranthambore put the number at 14, of which eight are said to be old, being above the age of 12. "My concern is that we are not finding carcasses of tigers dying of natural causes...we must also see if we have lost any or more tigers to poaching," says Bhardwaj. Khandal argues that the missing tigers can be explained logically. He says besides death of ageing tigers, some of the big cats have been sick. The weaker among the younger adults could have moved out to Madhya Pradesh or other forest areas.

Though there is no formal study on the average number of tigers that go untraced in a tiger reserve, the number is estimated to be three for Ranthambore. So, officials say that they must worry about at least half a dozen tigers that have not been spotted for a year, with no clear reasons attributed to their not being seen on camera or sighted by people.

The shocking revelation of missing tigers is another reason for the wildlife department to relook at its strategies to monitor tigers more effectively. The nation cannot afford to have a Sariska-like fiasco at Ranthambore. ■